PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

John Brown & Harpers Ferry — House & Divided

Martyr or Madman?

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about John Brown & Harpers Ferry — House & Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Americans could not agree on John Brown then, and historians argue about him now. Weigh the evidence — two images and his own words — and reach your own verdict

THE SOURCES

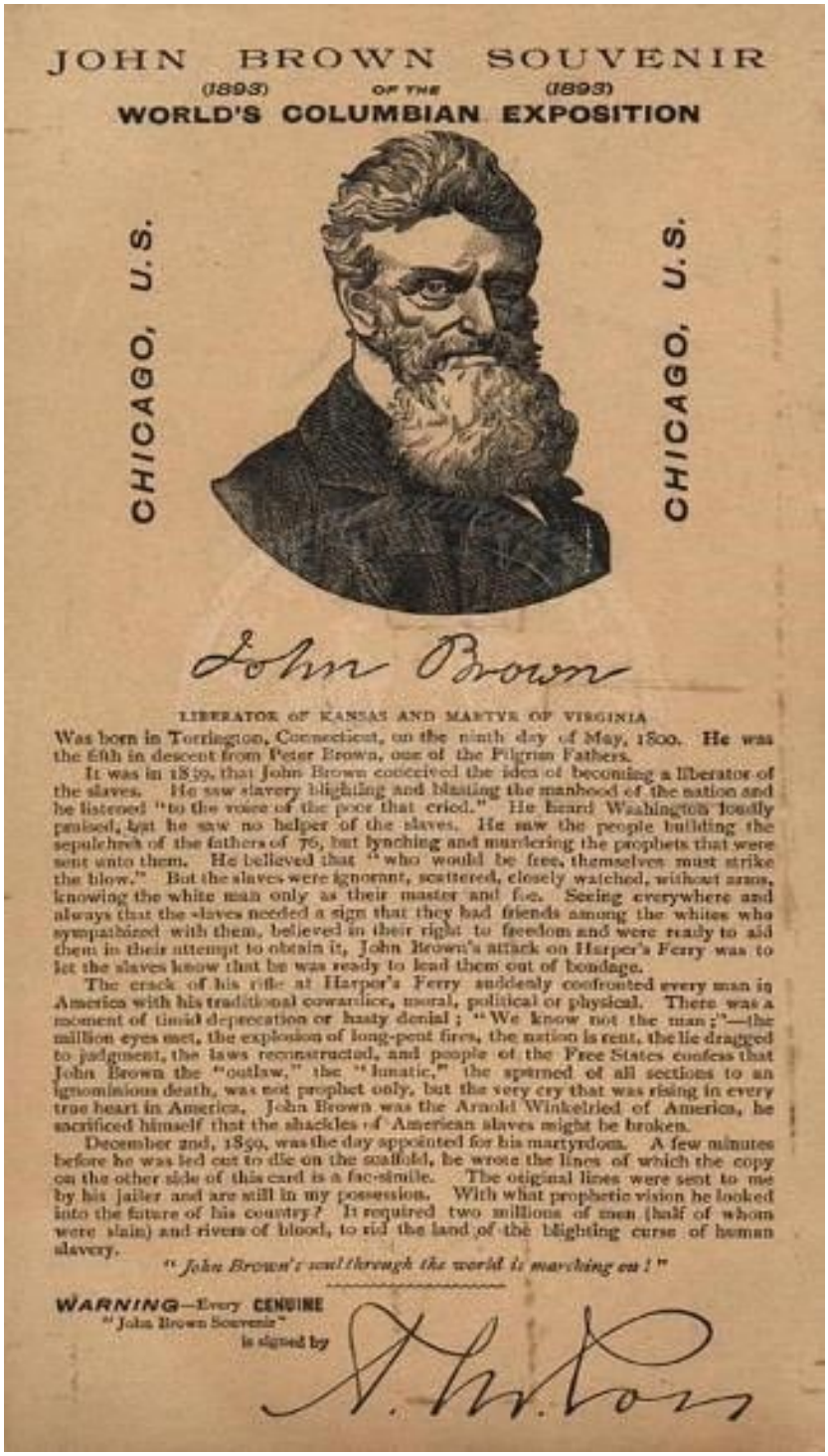
SOURCE A · HOW HIS ENEMIES SAW HIM — "A Premature Movement"



A hostile cartoon: Brown, wild-eyed, shoves a pike at an enslaved man who wants no part of it. The message — Brown was a dangerous fanatic forcing a fight nobody asked for

"A Premature Movement" — lithograph, c. 1859–60, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE B · HOW HIS ADMIRERS SAW HIM — "Liberator of Kansas and Martyr of Virginia"



JOHN BROWN SOUVENIR

(1893) OF THE (1893)

WORLD'S COLUMBIAN EXPOSITION

CHICAGO, U.S.

CHICAGO, U.S.

John Brown

LIBERATOR OF KANSAS AND MARTYR OF VIRGINIA

Was born in Torrington, Connecticut, on the ninth day of May, 1800. He was the fifth in descent from Peter Brown, one of the Pilgrim Fathers.

It was in 1839, that John Brown conceived the idea of becoming a liberator of the slaves. He saw slavery blighting and blasting the manhood of the nation and he listened "to the voice of the poor that cried." He heard Washington loudly praised, but he saw no helper of the slaves. He saw the people building the sepulchres of the fathers of 76, but lynching and murdering the prophets that were sent unto them. He believed that "who would be free, themselves must strike the blow." But the slaves were ignorant, scattered, closely watched, without arms, knowing the white man only as their master and foe. Seeing everywhere and always that the slaves needed a sign that they had friends among the whites who sympathized with them, believed in their right to freedom and were ready to aid them in their attempt to obtain it, John Brown's attack on Harper's Ferry was to let the slaves know that he was ready to lead them out of bondage.

The crack of his rifle at Harper's Ferry suddenly confronted every man in America with his traditional cowardice, moral, political or physical. There was a moment of timid deprecation or hasty denial; "We know not the man;"—the million eyes met, the explosion of long-pent fires, the nation is rent, the lie dragged to judgment, the laws reconstructed, and people of the Free States confess that John Brown the "outlaw," the "lunatic," the spurned of all sections to an ignominious death, was not prophet only, but the very cry that was rising in every true heart in America. John Brown was the Arnold Winkelried of America, he sacrificed himself that the shackles of American slaves might be broken.

December 2nd, 1859, was the day appointed for his martyrdom. A few minutes before he was led out to die on the scaffold, he wrote the lines of which the copy on the other side of this card is a fac-simile. The original lines were sent to me by his jailer and are still in my possession. With what prophetic vision he looked into the future of his country? It required two millions of men (half of whom were slain) and rivers of blood, to rid the land of the blighting curse of human slavery.

"John Brown's soul through the world is marching on!"

WARNING—Every **GENUINE** "John Brown Souvenir" is signed by

Decades later, this souvenir card honored Brown as a hero and "martyr" — a man who died for a holy cause

John Brown souvenir, World's Columbian Exposition, 1893, public domain. Collected image, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

SOURCE C · BROWN IN HIS OWN WORDS · 1859 — At his sentencing

"Had I so interfered in behalf of the rich, the powerful … every man in this court would have deemed it an act worthy of reward rather than punishment. … Now, if it is deemed necessary that I should … mingle my blood … with the blood of millions in this slave country whose rights are disregarded by wicked, cruel, and unjust

enactments, I say, let it be done."

— John Brown, address to the court, November 1859. Public domain

— John Brown, address to the court, November 1859. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · READ THE TWO IMAGES

Source A and Source B show the exact same person. What is each image trying to make you believe about John Brown? Name one detail in each that carries the message.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · HIS OWN DEFENSE

In Source C, what is Brown's main argument for why his actions were justified?

- ☐ A. that he didn't really break any law
- ☐ B. that the raid actually succeeded
- ☐ C. that acting for the enslaved is punished, while the same act for the powerful would be praised — so slavery is the true crime
- ☐ D. that he acted alone and regretted it

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · YOUR INTERPRETATION

His cause — ending slavery — was just. His method — violence and armed insurrection — killed people and failed. Was John Brown a hero/martyr, a dangerous fanatic, or something in between? Take a position and defend it with at least one source (A, B, or C).

QUESTION 4 STEP 3 · YOUR INTERPRETATION

Historians note that a person's reputation can change over time. Why might Brown be seen as a villain in 1859 but closer to a hero today? What changed?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — John Brown & Harpers Ferry — House & Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Source A wants me to see Brown as… (detail: …). Source B wants me to see him as… (detail: …)."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. that acting for the enslaved is punished, while the same act for the powerful would be praised — so slavery is the true crime**

Right. Brown argues that acting violently for the enslaved is treated as a crime, while the same act for the rich and powerful would be praised — so the real injustice is slavery itself, not his attempt to end it.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I think John Brown was… My strongest evidence is…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Views of Brown changed because…"